



Phonekerchief

A new product called Phonekerchief is meant to block cell phone reception when you are out on a romantic date

Zuckerberg in animation

After a cameo in Simpsons, Facebook CEO Mark Zuckerberg will be featured in his own cartoon

more often than other brands. Sony takes the number two spot here.

4. Stylish? Apple all the way, with Sony trailing by 9 per cent. Samsung comes in third here, not surprising, given they have some very stylish PMPs.
5. Ease of use? People feel that iPods are complicated. Don't ask us why, but the fact that Apple is perceived to be a lifestyle brand could have something to do with it. Sony wins here.
6. Sony's campaigning for their Walkman players has paid off. Last year they were two and a half times behind Apple, in terms of awareness and this surely hurt their sales, for how can people buy a brand they've not heard of? This year, they're just 8 per cent behind Apple. That's a whopping bit of catching up they've done.
7. Last year, Sony enjoyed a lead in the credibility ratings. This year, Apple has caught up to them, and both brands have tied. We feel the newer iPods being cheaper has fed their adoption rate, and this has lead to an increase in credibility i.e. simply more people bought Apple PMPs than last year.
8. More people are satisfied with their Sony Walkmans, than Apple users with their iPods. This must surely be disturbing for people, and we feel it's largely because of the hype surrounding Apple PMPs. A lot of people buy them, and use them and go "they're good, but they're not that good". The corollary being expect too much from a product, and you're sure to be dissatisfied. Yes, we made that up!
9. Sony has gained trust over Apple, and surpasses them by a point. Last year Apple led by a point. We're talking about overall trust, and there's a fight brewing here folks. Samsung quietly slips into the number three spot, overtaking Philips and Creative – two companies that we haven't seen many PMPs from in the last year. Out of sight, out of mind?

The most trusted

Sony steals the show here, no doubt some very good models and a better brand recall has helped them. Apple occupies the number two position. Samsung is at number three. Philips and Creative tie for the fourth and fifth spot.

Hard Drives

Amidst the glamour of SSDs and flash storage, we have these, the archaic stalwarts. Comparing a HDD to an SSD is akin to a sports car to a sedan. However, speed doesn't come cheap. And a sedan might be easier to live with in the long run. Back to hard drives. They're the cost-to-gigabyte kings, and SSDs can only dream of the value that a hard drive can provide. Hard drives haven't gotten significantly faster, although the latest generation are speedier than previous one. However, storage is on the increase, and of course hybrid hard drives (ones that use flash and magnetic storage) are hiding in the wings.

Market Trends

Flash has gotten a bit cheaper. So what? Hard drives have become even more so. Imagine, you can buy a reasonably fast 1.5 terabyte hard drive for merely Rs. 4,500. And a two-terabyte drive for around Rs. 6,500. Now that's a lot of storage. And people are demanding more. We're seeing a trend where people are opting for multiple hard drives. Buy one, fill it up, and then purchase another, seems to be the ethos and we love it. Obviously, there's no end for data glut-tony and we've seen three terabyte hard drives enter the market, although at a higher cost. By 2011 they are sure to become more affordable.

Hybrid hard drives are available, but it seems nobody's biting. The higher price is probably the killjoy. We've also seen brands clearly

distinguish between performance and power saving options, with WD creating a Black, Blue and Green series, effectively doing away with unnecessary model numbers.

Notebook hard drives have also received a shot in the arm in terms of storage. It seemed 500 GB was a ceiling for quite a while, but now, 750 GB and one terabyte drives are available in the 2.5-inch form factor. They're faster than 500 GB drives, owing to higher areal densities, and their prices have gone through one revision. With another, we feel they'll be worth the upgrade. Similarly, external hard drives have also become more voluminous. At the moment, the speed race seems to be largely defunct. If you want blazing performance, you'll go SSD. However, we've seen some SAS drives typically seen in server and workstation setups being marketed for uber desktops. Although rare, and expensive, these 12,000 and 15,000 rpm drives do pack a punch.

Perceptions from our survey

1. One of the most shocking figures was the awareness index. Seagate is 75 per cent ahead of Western Digital. We were surprised too. This belies the fact that many hard drive vendors push Western Digital more, a trend we've seen in market places like Nehru Place (Delhi) and Lamington Road (Mumbai). Evidently, Seagate's reputation of old means that simply more people have heard of the brand. However, both Seagate and WD have better awareness scores this year, when com-

